

Headaches & Migraine

Headaches and migraine can be very debilitating, especially when they occur frequently.

Headaches are caused by many factors, such as toothache, neck tension, eyestrain, and hangovers. It is important to diagnose and treat the underlying cause, which could mean visiting a dentist, optician, or osteopath in the first instance. Herbal medicine can be very helpful for headaches, although choosing the right herbs can be difficult. The following remedies contain relaxing herbs that alleviate headaches triggered by stress as well as other more specific factors. Lavender is soothing, while vervain is a tonic and relaxing herb for nervous exhaustion. Peppermint is effective for headaches that are linked to indigestion.

Migraine is a more specific problem. The remedies aim both to prevent the onset of a migraine as well as treat the symptoms.

Hangovers are not a nerve problem in a direct sense, but they should be treated in the same way as any other type of mild poisoning that requires detoxification and headache relief. Make sure you also drink plenty of water.

General caution For migraine or recurrent headaches, consult a professional practitioner to diagnose and treat the underlying cause.

General Remedy

Herb Lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108)

Remedy Rub a few drops of neat essential oil on the temples.

Tension & Sinus Headaches

Herb Linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277)

Remedy Make an infusion using 1 heaping tsp of linden to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water; or use teabags. Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Nervous Exhaustion & Overactivity

Herbs Vervain (*Verbena officinalis*, p. 149), valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148)

Remedy Make an infusion of vervain and drink up to $2\frac{1}{4}$ cups a day. Alternatively, mix $\frac{1}{2}$ tsp of each tincture and take with water up to 3 times a day.

Caution Do not take vervain during pregnancy.

Digestive Headaches & Biliousness

Herbs Peppermint (*Mentha x piperita*, p. 114), pennyroyal (*Mentha pulegium*, p. 235)

Remedy Make an infusion of either herb in a covered container; using a teabag, a small handful of fresh leaves, or 1 level tsp of dried herb per $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day for up to 1 week, or up to $2\frac{1}{3}$ cups (600 ml) a day if taking for 2–3 weeks.

Cautions Do not give to children under 5. Do not take pennyroyal during pregnancy.

Migraine Prevention

Herb Feverfew (*Tanacetum parthenium*, p. 140)

Remedy At the first sign of an impending attack, take tablets or 10 drops of tincture with water. Alternatively, place a fresh leaf between slices of bread and eat as a sandwich.

Cautions Do not give to children under 12. Do not take in pregnancy.

Migraine

Herb Skullcap (*Scutellaria lateriflora*, p. 135)

Remedy Make an infusion using 1 heaping tsp of herb to $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Drink up to 3 cups (750 ml) a day.

Herb Rosemary (*Rosmarinus officinalis*, p. 128)

Remedy Make an infusion using 1 level tsp of herb per $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water and take up to $2\frac{1}{2}$ cups (600 ml) each day.

Detoxification for Hangover

Herb Dandelion (*Taraxacum officinale*, p. 141)

Remedy Make a decoction using 15 g of root to 3 cups (750 ml) of water. Take the decoction in small quantities at frequent intervals throughout the day.

Insomnia

Difficulty in sleeping affects everyone at one time or another. Herbs can provide a safe and gentle solution to this problem.

Sedative herbs such as German chamomile, linden, lavender, hops, and passionflower are relaxing and, unlike some herbs, are most likely to be effective against insomnia when taken at night. Hops are excellent when the mind refuses to “switch off.”

Stimulant herbs are effective when the body suffers from nervous exhaustion and feels, paradoxically, too tired for sleep. Oats and ginseng encourage a good night's sleep, especially for people suffering from nervous tension and fatigue.

Herbal sleeping pills, containing combinations of valerian, hops, passionflower, and similar herbs, are often helpful in overcoming mild sleep problems and in reducing feelings of anxiety and stress.

General Remedies

Herbs German chamomile (*Chamomilla recutita*, p. 77), linden (*Tilia* spp., p. 277), lavender (*Lavandula officinalis*, p. 108), passionflower (*Passiflora incarnata*, p. 119)

Remedy The above herbs are listed in ascending order of strength. Start with the weakest, German chamomile, and if it does not help, try the next strongest. Make an infusion in a covered container using 1–2 heaping tsp per $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) of water. Take prior to sleeping. Alternatively, take 1 tsp of tincture with water up to 3 times a night.

Herbs Valerian (*Valeriana officinalis*, p. 148), hops (*Humulus lupulus*, p. 104), passionflower (*Passiflora incarnata*, p. 119)

Remedy 1 Take tablets containing one or more of the herbs.

Remedy 2 Make a sachet with dried hops (see p. 104) and place inside your pillow.

Caution Do not take hops internally if feeling low or depressed.

Overactive Mind

Herb Hops (*Humulus lupulus*, p. 104)

Remedy Take the tincture with water at night. Start with 10 drops up to a maximum of 40 drops each night.

Caution Do not take hops internally if feeling low or depressed.

Poor sleep & nervous exhaustion

Herb Oats (*Avena sativa*, p. 175)

Remedy Eat oats daily, for example as a hot cereal, and take 1 tsp of oat straw tincture with water 3 times a day.

Herbs Ashwagandha (*Withania somnifera*, p. 152), Siberian ginseng (*Eleutherococcus senticosus*, p. 94)

Remedy Take 1–2 g of ashwagandha or Siberian ginseng up to 3 times a day. Either chew the root, or cook it in a soup. Alternatively, take tablets.

Cautions Avoid taking caffeine while taking ashwagandha and Siberian ginseng. Do not take Siberian ginseng for more than 6 weeks at a time. Do not take during pregnancy. Do not give to children under 12.